



COLOURS OF TOGETHERNESS: A Muslim prince celebrates Holi in his harem

from India are often the highest achievers, the least militant, most accommodating, hardly ever likely to be involved in terrorist activities or put under police surveillance, and by and large comfortable with secular modernity. In an affray involving Pakistani and Indian Muslim migrants to Britain some years ago, the two communities hurled abuses at each other. The former accused the latter of the being "jootha (impure)" or "Hindu Muslims", that is, Muslims contaminated by India's Hindu culture. The Indian Muslims rejoined that the Pakistanis were all "fanatical", "fundamentalist" and "backward". Indian Muslims bring to their religion the pluralist sensibility derived from their Indian heritage. This is also true of Indian Christians whose reading of their religion is less dogmatic and absolutist than that of their counterparts in many other societies.

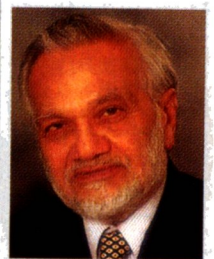
Thanks to our syncretic culture and its pluralist ethos, we are at home with differences, sometimes more than we should be. We appreciate that there is no single model of a good Indian. Each of us has a different personal and political biography, and appropriates India in his or her own different way. We are also embedded in our regional cultures and identities, which deeply matter to us and mediate our relations with our

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Indian identity. We do feel at home in India, but are inevitably more at home in some parts of it than in others. Our strong regional loyalties nurture the national. One does not need to stop being a proud Bengali or Kashmiri in order to be a proud Indian. We have seen in recent years how regional pride, whether in Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat or Karnataka, can release great entrepreneurial energy and stimulate new political experiments without undermining the commitment to national unity and well-being.

Even the atrocities committed after the Godhra train incident did not shake the Muslims' faith in India. Although they were rightly angry with the government of Gujarat, they loved its language, customs, easy-going manners, tolerance, commercial spirit and hospitality. This explains the fact that Gujarati Muslims settled abroad did not have a bad opinion of Gujarat and its people. They continued to visit the state just as they had done before. Our composite culture has been a great source of stability and energy. Even when groups of people are unhappy with the policies of the government, their anger against the government does not translate into that against the country, a common phenomenon in many other societies.

The Sangh Parivar is patriotic and loves India, albeit in its own way. But there is not a shadow of doubt that its ideology of purging Indian culture of its so-called foreign elements is driven by the fundamentally false belief that India was partitioned along religious lines and that the continuing Muslim presence in India is either culturally illegitimate or an expression of Hindu generosity. India was not partitioned along religious lines, rather Pakistan was sliced off along religious lines with the rest of India remaining what it had always been, a multi-religious and multicultural country. Indian Muslims do not represent the unfinished agenda of the Partition. They are, like other communities, an integral and valued part of the country, and have contributed most generously to the creation of our composite culture.



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